OTT

The Great Indian Village

Everyone's favourite OTT show, ***Panchayat***, is back for a third season on Amazon Prime Video. Expect a lot of laughs



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Call it a funny coincidence. The makers of *Panchayat* didn't purposefully intend to have their third season, one revolving around panchayat polls, release in the midst of a general election. The new season drops on Amazon Prime Video on May 28, and since there's plenty of politicking, it isn't always a pretty picture. "It is out-and-out about political rivalry," says series director Deepak Kumar Mishra. "You've seen a sweet Pradhaan, but election *hota hai, to leaders ka face bilkul badal jaata hai* [come election time, people change]." And, unlike last season, which ended on a surprisingly gut-punching note, this time around, there'll be no need for tissues, assures Mishra. "*Khoob hasaaoonga* (I'll make you laugh). Expect fun, political drama and emotions."

Four years since the first season dropped, *Panchayat* has acquired a devoted fandom, with its endearing central characters—Pradhaan, Vikas, Prahlad, Manju Devi, Rinki and Sachivji—becoming household names. For writer Chandan Kumar, their appeal lies in that "they are nice, but flawed people. They do err but still are loveable". The show's popularity is further evident in how it has inspired a series of memes, including "*Dekh raha hai, Binodh*". "It is unexpected for us what the audience picks up," says Mishra. "We don't let what's happening outside affect us; we try to be honest to the story. Fanboy *wali cheez nahin karni hai* [We don't let the fans sway us]." Although Mishra admits that Chandan and he keep track of the audience chatter online.

What *Panchayat* has also done is fill a void by showing village life on OTT. In doing so, it has put Mahodiya, a village in Madhya Pradesh, which goes by the name of Phulera in the show, on the nation's map. The past few years have seen the development of a *pucca* road (also a plot point in season one), a school, a temple and a revamped panchayat office. The residents are by now familiar with the cast and crew, welcoming them for two months and occasionally asking why they didn't stick to the village's original name. "These places are alive where people are quiet and lovely and the relationships matter to them," says Faisal Malik, who plays Prahlad. "[For me] coming back to shooting with the same people for two months doesn't feel an outdoor shoot but a retreat. *Mazaa hota hai, kaam nahin lagta* [It feels like fun, not work]."

The audience has noticed the bonhomie and responded to the show with warmth. The challenge for Mishra and writer Chandan Kumar has been to keep their interest going by delivering an equally good new season within two years and come up with more relatable situations to put the characters through. For Kumar, the quest is to "not repeat ourselves and go deeper into the story and get into the characters' minds" season by season. That they both enjoy doing so is the icing on the cake. "I know what I am going to put them through in seasons four and five," says Mishra. Faisal Khan, who is seated next to him, smiles. Bring on the adventure. ■

–Suhani Singh